

MGT 431: POWER AND POLITICS

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HYBRID EMBA

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DESCRIPTION

In any organization, it is not enough to have a good idea or a brilliant plan; you need the cooperation and support of others to get things done. Organizations are fundamentally political entities, and power and influence are key mechanisms by which things are accomplished. This course will encourage you to think about and develop your own personal path to power—which can, of course, include a path away from power. Together we will work to build your political intelligence. Power is a topic that can make people uncomfortable, but it is a critical part of organizational life, and this course will provide a safe space to work through this discomfort.

INSTRUCTIONAL METHODS

The core of this course will be 1) discussion of the materials and 2) exercises designed to help you gain and practice skills. Any lecturing I do will be geared towards further illuminating concepts and issues and guiding discussion. As this is a hybrid course, most weeks you will watch my lectures on video and have discussion on Canvas, but other weeks, class will be in person. During these in-person weeks, you will also take part in exercises.

Throughout this course, we will use multiple methodologies:

- ***Analysis and discussion of articles and cases.*** You will be expected to share your relevant management and leadership experiences.
- ***In-class exercises to illustrate and practice course concepts.***
- ***Assignments to practice and apply course concepts.*** You will be learning concrete skills throughout this class. You will regularly be asked to practice these skills outside the classroom and then discuss your experience. You will also write reflection papers to help you synthesize the various topics covered in class and apply them to your own career, in terms of both previous experiences and anticipated issues in the future.

OBJECTIVES

The overall course objective is for you to gain knowledge, skills, and strategies related to power that will help you become highly effective and impactful in your career. By the end of this course, you will:

- Develop a healthy respect for power and how it can affect people. You will know the benefits as well as the costs and pitfalls associated with the pursuit and acquisition of power.
- See the world differently. You will become more sensitive to power dynamics and recognize the true distribution of power in organizations. You will learn to assess how various decisions affect a person's level of power and be able to identify alternative actions and opportunities that would have been more/less likely to lead to power.
- Act differently. You will learn and practice new skills that you will continue to hone throughout your career. By the end of class, you will have developed a personal strategic plan that will help you identify and build your own personal path to power based on your individual strengths, professional goals, and personal values.

REQUIRED MATERIALS

- Pfeffer, J. (2010). *Power: Why Some People Have It—And Others Don't*. New York: HarperCollins.
- Course reader and other readings posted directly on Canvas

All course materials are available on Canvas, including details about assignments, readings and case studies, instructions for exercises, recorded lectures for asynchronous content, and copies of slide decks. (During in-person weeks, slide decks will be posted after class.) You should approach the readings with a critical eye guided by your own experience and expertise, while also considering the questions and prompts provided on Canvas.

Please bring a laptop or tablet with you to in-person sessions. You will need it to complete in-class exercises and to access the readings for discussion.

ASSIGNMENTS

There are no group assignments for this class. All assignments should be completed individually, with some consultation and discussion with others as relevant.

Class Participation (37%)

Your course participation grade will be based on 1) your timely completion of course-related activities outside of class (i.e., surveys; 3% of grade), and 2) your contributions to class discussion (34% of grade). During asynchronous weeks, class discussion will occur on Canvas discussion boards. Full participation for one of these weeks will involve both responding to the questions posted and engaging with your classmates' posts (e.g., answering questions they raise, offering your perspective, providing relevant information). The quality of your posts is more important than the quantity.

During in-person weeks, class discussion will occur in person. It is essential that you come to each in-person class prepared, meaning you have completed all assignments (i.e., readings, surveys, reflection papers) for that week. Coming to class unprepared will interfere with your ability to participate in discussions and learn from the course in general. Similar to asynchronous weeks, your goal during in-class discussions should be to contribute *high-quality* comments, not a *high quantity* of comments. This means you must listen carefully to the

comments of your classmates—listening to others and engaging with them is a key part of the learning process in this course (and a key element of gaining influence!).

You cannot take part in in-class discussions if you are not in class, but I understand that absences are sometimes unavoidable. **You must tell me if you expect to miss a class (or part of it) and why. If there is a good reason you cannot attend class, please contact me in advance and I can give you an assignment to complete to earn participation credit for that missed class.** Unexplained absences will hurt your grade, and multiple absences (explained or not) will hinder your ability to learn from this class. It is not possible to attend in-person class over Zoom.

Reflection Papers (18%)

A reflection paper is designed to encourage you to relate the class material to your own career. In writing these papers, do not repeat what we have all read or discussed during class. Rather, use the available space (no more than 2 pages, double-spaced, 1-inch margins) to reflect on how the material applies to you, following the prompt provided. Please post each paper on Canvas by the due date.

The grading scheme is designed so that almost all reflection papers will receive a 100, if they are submitted on time and respond to the prompt provided. Such a grade indicates you are putting the expected thought and effort into these papers. For this reason, these papers will often not be given specific feedback. I am always available if you want to talk about your reflection paper content or grade.

Final Paper (45%)

The final paper is designed to help you strategize for the next few years of your career (and beyond). It will give you an opportunity to apply the concepts and lessons of this course to your present job, or to the job you plan to secure after graduation.

Your paper should address the following five questions:

1. What are the power dynamics inherent in your current job/future job?
2. What sources of power and influence will you need to be effective?
3. Do your current sources of power and influence fit the requirements of the job? Explain.
4. What are the ethical dilemmas for which you will need to be vigilant?
5. What is your plan for developing the sources of power, influence skills, and social network necessary to be effective
 - a. currently/before taking the job,
 - b. during your first year after graduating, and
 - c. a few years down the road?

One way to get a sense of a political environment is to talk to people who have been there. As part of this assignment, you are required to conduct one informational interview with someone who is qualified to speak about the political environment that surrounds the position you have or the position you seek. About one page of your paper should be dedicated to (briefly) discussing this informational interview: Think about the interview you conducted for your final paper. Why did you choose this individual? What are some primary insights you gained from your conversation with them? You do not need to name this person (and they are likely to be more

open with you knowing they will not be named in your paper!), but you should give me a sense of whom they are (e.g., their position).

Final papers should be typed, double-spaced, 12-point font, and no longer than 12 pages. The paper is due March 18. Your grade will reflect the breadth and depth of your analysis and the creative insights you offer. I want this process to be valuable to your professional life. If you would like to adjust some aspect of the final product to best fit your needs, please check with me first.

GRADING

Assignment	Percentage of final grade
Course participation: class discussions	34%
Course participation: surveys	3%
Reflection papers	18%
Final paper	45%
TOTAL	100%

COURSE POLICIES

Attendance Policy

This course follows a hybrid structure, with only three in-person sessions. Our time together in person is limited, and I want us to make the most of it. You must tell me if you expect to miss one of our in-person sessions (even part of one) and why. If there is a good reason you cannot attend class, please contact me **in advance** and I can give you an assignment to complete to earn participation credit for that missed class. Unexplained absences will hurt your grade, and multiple absences (explained or not) will hinder your ability to learn from this class.

It is not possible for you to attend in-person sessions over Zoom. These sessions will involve exercises that cannot be completed remotely.

Generative AI Policy

This policy applies to use of various new generative AI tools that can generate responses of various types (e.g., text, images) to prompts by users (e.g., ChatGPT, BingChat, Bard, Midjourney, etc.). These new tools can streamline and augment our work but can also dull our critical thinking skills. You are permitted to use these tools for this class under these circumstances:

- You may use these tools to refine your initial work, but not to generate an entire paper you then claim as your own. This course is focused on your personal experience and growth, and you will gain little from the course if you leave all the writing (and thus the thinking) to generative AI.
- If you use generative AI for an assignment, be transparent how you used it. I am not fussed about how you make this acknowledgment (e.g., footnote, separate section at end of paper), just that you do it.

- You are ultimately responsible for the work you turn in. Be aware that assistance from Generative AI may also include inaccuracies (e.g., hallucinations) being added to your work.

Late Policy

You will not get credit for completing surveys late, as I can only use your data if you submit it on time. If you turn in a reflection paper or the final paper late, I will deduct 5% from your grade for every 24 hours it is late. If you feel you have unusual circumstances that would make such deductions inappropriate, please let me know before the deadline (if possible, or soon afterwards) and we can discuss your situation.

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

Integrity of scholarship is essential for an academic community. As members of the Rady School, we pledge ourselves to uphold the highest ethical standards. The University expects that both faculty and students will honor this principle and in so doing protect the validity of University intellectual work. For students, this means that all academic work will be done by the individual to whom it is assigned, without unauthorized aid of any kind.

The complete UCSD Policy on Integrity of Scholarship can be viewed at:

<http://senate.ucsd.edu/Operating-Procedures/Senate-Manual/Appendices/2>

STUDENTS WITH DISABILITIES

A student who has a disability or special need and requires an accommodation in order to have equal access to the classroom must register with the Office for Students with Disabilities (OSD). The OSD will determine what accommodations may be made and provide the necessary documentation to present to the faculty member.

The student must present the OSD letter of certification and OSD accommodation recommendation to the appropriate faculty member in order to initiate the request for accommodation in classes, examinations, or other academic program activities. **No accommodations can be implemented retroactively.**

Please visit the [OSD website](#) for further information or contact the Office for Students with Disabilities at (858) 534-4382 or osd@ucsd.edu.

DETAILED SCHEDULE

CLASS 1. Course Introduction

In person

Before class

- Complete Attitudes Towards Politics Survey (due Jan 9, 5 pm)
- Write Reflection Paper 1 (due Jan 10, 8 am)
- Read The Truth about Power (Gruenfeld)

CLASS 2. Sources of Power

Asynchronous

Before you watch any videos

- Read Chapters 1 and 3 of Pfeffer book
- LBJ case: Read On His Way and In Tune

Next

- Watch lecture videos
- Complete Canvas Discussion Board participation (due Jan 18, 11:59 pm)

CLASS 3. Principles of Influence

Asynchronous

Before you watch any videos

- Read Harnessing the Science of Persuasion (Cialdini)
- Select a principle to try out in real life. Go out and do it. Then complete the Cialdini Survey about your experience (due Jan 25, 11:59 PM)

Next

- Watch lecture videos
- Complete Canvas Discussion Board participation (due Jan 25, 11:59 pm)

CLASS 4. Managing Reputations

Asynchronous

Before you watch any videos

- Read Chapter 8 of Pfeffer book
- Sonnenfeld case: Read Jeffrey Sonnenfeld (A): The Fall from Grace

Next

- Watch lecture videos
- Complete Canvas Discussion Board participation (due Feb 1, 11:59 pm)

CLASS 5. Star Power

In person

Before class

- No prep!

CLASS 6. Acting with Power

Asynchronous

Before you watch any videos

- Complete the Self-Monitoring Scale Survey (due Feb 15, 11:59 pm)
- Read The Authenticity Paradox (Ibarra) and Getting in Character (Gruenfeld)

Next

- Watch lecture videos
- Complete Canvas Discussion Board participation (due Feb 15, 11:59 pm)

Anytime during this week

- Complete Reflection Paper 2 (due Feb 15, 11:59 pm). Note that completing this paper requires you to talk with a colleague, so make sure you allow sufficient time for this.

CLASS 7. Relating to Others

Asynchronous

Before you watch any videos

- Read Ten Things Every Manager Should Know about Nonverbal Behavior (Carney)

Next

- Watch lecture videos
- Complete Canvas Discussion Board participation (due Feb 22, 11:59 pm)

CLASS 8. Assessing Your Social Capital

Asynchronous

Before you watch any videos

- Read A Note on Social Networks and Network Structure (Pfeffer)
- Complete the Network Assessment Exercise Survey (due Mar 1, 11:59 pm). Note that you will need up to 30 minutes to complete this.
- Complete Reflection Paper 3 (due Mar 1, 11:59 pm). Note that you need to complete the survey first before you can complete the reflection paper.

Next

- Watch the lecture video
- Complete Canvas Discussion Board participation (due Mar 1, 11:59 pm)

CLASS 9. Improving Your Social Capital

In person

Before class

- Read Network Across and Out (Ibarra)

CLASS 10. Coalitions and Alliances

Asynchronous

Before you watch any videos

- Read Who Controls Access to What We Value? (Battilana & Casciaro)
- Rinaldi case: Read Martha Rinaldi: Should She Stay or Should She Go?

Next

- Watch lecture videos
- Complete Canvas Discussion Board participation (due Mar 15, 11:59 pm)

Final paper due March 18, 11:59 pm